

The Gazette DOLLARSWORTH

The Free Guide to Money Saving Bargains



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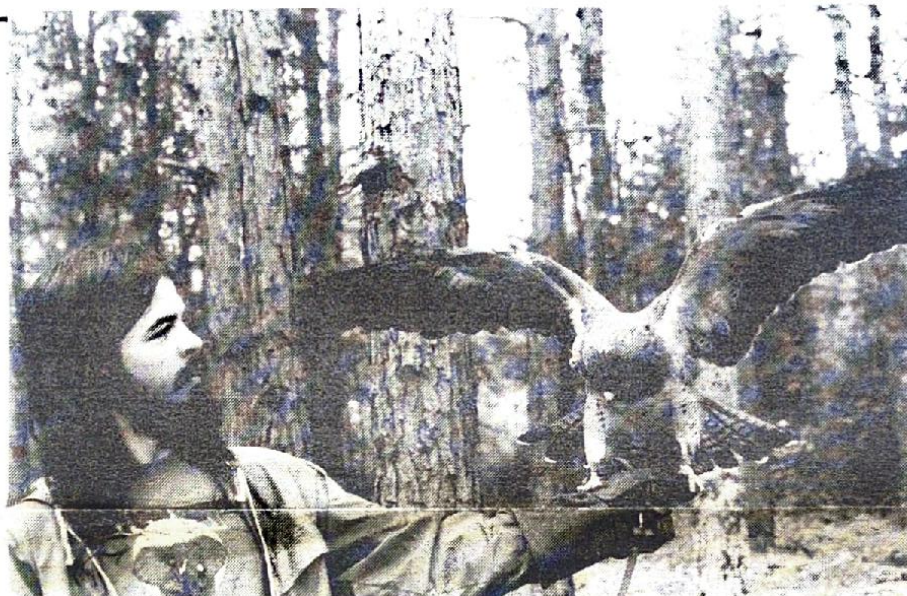
Thursday, April 25, 1985—DOLLARSWORTH—1



FREE

Take

One



Mathias Englemann and hawk friend Terry entertain visitors at the Carolina Raptor Center at Latta

Plantation Park. (Photo by Pat Johnson)

FREE

Take

One

Raptor Center at Latta Invites Visitors

If you are looking for something to do on a Saturday or Sunday afternoon, take a trip to Latta Plantation Park and visit the new site of the Carolina Raptor Center.

Currently there are only a couple of mobile buildings, many cages and a small arena with several perches used for public display of the birds of prey. There are many birds and there are many dedicated volunteers involved to help any visitor understand the beauty and mystique of these birds.

Located within the confines of a Mecklenburg County Park, the Raptor Center is located on 80 acres which was donated to them by Mecklenburg County.

Volunteer Mathias Englemann explained that the Raptor Center has been housed at UNCC; however the program was founded as an independent program and only located at UNCC until another permanent area could be found.

"Right now we don't have a lot to show, however, there are plans in the working but it is hard to say when we'll have the funds to do everything," explained Englemann. "We will

someday see permanent buildings which will house an environmental center with a bird of prey theme. There will be classrooms and a permanent medical building and a nature trail with birds of prey displayed along the route."

Dr. Richard Brown is the executive director and founder of the Raptor Center. Davidson's Dr. Verna Case serves as Board president. The program is financially held together by donations in addition to donations of veterinary time, food for the raptors, and even one of the mobile buildings on the property.

According to Englemann, volunteers provide rats for feeding the birds, however, the expense of this to individuals is quite high. Scrap poultry meat is donated by a local market, and area restaurant donates fish and Holly Farms donates baby chicks.

"Diet is so important, more so in captivity, and diet can be the decision factor whether a bird survives while in captivity," cited Englemann.

A visit to the Raptor Center will bring you in touch with a

variety of birds of prey. During a recent Saturday's visit, Englemann had on display a Northern Goshawk, a Red Tailed Hawk, a Swainson's Hawk and a variety of owls. There are many other varieties which can be brought out at different times.

The Raptor Center currently has two American Bald Eagles. King George sits in a Gazebo type building eyeing each visitor with interest. There is also a female eagle which was released in Albany, N.Y. as part of a re-introduction program and shot in N.C. in December.

"She will most probably be returned to New York State," explained Englemann. "The person who released her would like her back for possible breeding purposes."

The Raptor Center does not get well birds, only those which have been victims of some accident or human misuse. If the birds can be rehabilitated, they are, and local veterinarians, Drs. Messenger, Allen, and Goch-nauer contribute their time and medication to attempt to accomplish this feat.

The Raptor Center has been

invited to participate in the dedication of Latta Plantation Park's Visitor Center on April 27, and Englemann hopes they will be able to release a Red Tailed Hawk on that date.

Visitors can stop by the Carolina Raptor Center weekends between 12-5. There is no fee but a donation jar awaits your contribution if you are able. Raptor Center volunteer and Administrative Coordinator, Joey Cochran may be the person who is on site that day to talk about each bird, stress the problem of that bird and answer questions. Other volunteers also give programs to the public.

At this time, as always, the Raptor Center can use financial contributions. They are also in need of dedicated volunteers, and Englemann explained that anyone with a sincere interest can be trained to work with the birds.

Also needed is at least one more mobile home to put on the Latta Park facility until a permanent structure can be built.

If you wish to volunteer or ask questions regarding the Carolina Raptor Center, you may call 597-4958 or 875-1909.

Very well done 1985